

The 4C Wash Day Checklist

Every step in order — from pre-poo to protection. Print it, tape it to the bathroom mirror, check it off.

- ☐ **1 Pre-Poo** 30 MIN – OVERNIGHT BEFORE WASHING
 Coat dry hair in sections with a penetrating oil (coconut or avocado). This shields the strand from wash-day swelling and protein loss before water ever touches it.
- ☐ **2 Section & Finger-Detangle** WORK IN 4–8 SECTIONS
 Divide hair into twisted sections. Gently separate the big tangles with fingers only — **never a comb on dry 4C hair**. Keep sections twisted through the whole wash.
- ☐ **3 Shampoo the Scalp** EVERY 1–2 WEEKS
 Sulfate-free shampoo massaged into the scalp with fingertips (not nails). Let the suds rinse through the length — that's enough cleansing for the ends. One section at a time.
- ☐ **4 Detangle with Conditioner** ENDS FIRST, ROOTS LAST
 Apply a slippery rinse-out conditioner, then detangle each section with a wide-tooth comb starting at the ends and working up. The slip is what prevents breakage.
- ☐ **5 Deep Condition — With Heat** 15–30 MIN, EVERY WASH DAY
 Coat every strand root to tip. Cover with a cap and add heat: a steamer is best (opens the cuticle so conditioner actually absorbs), a warm towel over the cap works too. Rinse with **cool** water to seal.
- ☐ **6 L — Liquid / Leave-In** ON SOAKING WET HAIR
 Water-based leave-in conditioner applied generously in sections. This is the moisture every later step is designed to keep in.
- ☐ **7 O — Oil** FOCUS ON THE ENDS
 Seal the leave-in with an oil — Jamaican black castor oil for thick 4C, grapeseed if your hair is finer or low porosity. Oil locks moisture in; it doesn't add it.
- ☐ **8 C — Cream, Then Style** STYLE WHILE DAMP
 Layer a curl cream over the oil, then style: twists, braids, or gel for a wash-and-go. Applying gel? Hair should still be dripping. **Hands off until fully dry.**
- ☐ **9 Protect Overnight** EVERY SINGLE NIGHT
 Silk or satin bonnet, scarf, or pillowcase. Cotton steals in one night the moisture you spent all wash day putting in.

THE RULES THAT MAKE IT WORK

- Moisture first, always: oil and cream on dry hair = sealed-in dryness. Water, then everything else.
- Detangle only with slip — conditioner in, ends first, fingers before tools.
- Once a month, swap the deep conditioner for a protein treatment if hair feels overly stretchy or limp.
- Mid-week refresh: spray water + a little leave-in, re-seal ends with oil. No full re-wash needed.